

Introduction

The Wanda Alston Foundation is a non-profit organization based in Washington, D.C. dedicated to providing housing for homeless and at-risk members of the LGBTQ community between ages 18 to 24. In addition to ensuring that these vulnerable and marginalized individuals have a safe place to live in, the Wanda Alston Foundation also offers numerous social services such as mental health counseling and job training programs to equip the youth with necessary qualities and skills to thrive in the nation's capital. Established in 2004, the Wanda Alston Foundation has served dozens of youth and substantially relies on volunteers, donations, and fundraising events to keep the organization afloat. In 2020, the COVID-19 pandemic disrupted many of the organization's services as they were abruptly forced to operate remotely. With the help of DCivitas, the Wanda Alston Foundation was able to smoothly transition their operations to a virtual setting while improving internal policies and enhancing their online presence.

Challenge

Wanda Alston Foundation's main struggle lay in having to suddenly pivot their services and events to virtual platforms as they have conventionally only planned in-person events and had no existing systems prepared to accommodate online events. Their main goal was to successfully organize their first ever virtual fundraiser in celebration of their newly opened housing facility and to effectively utilize social media to promote this event and their other services. Lastly, they wanted to create an employee handbook to provide more organizational clarity and to ensure that the policies and procedures of the workplace remain transparent even after shifting to a remote and virtual environment.

Strategy

DCivitas' team of nine consultants actively worked with Wanda Alston Foundation's executive director June Crenshaw and human resource manager Andrew Eschrich, by delegating tasks, formulating solutions, and establishing project deadlines during weekly meetings. The consultants connected with a virtual planner to organize the virtual fundraiser and reached out to a social media coordinator to discuss the social media campaign. They also created and sent out a survey to the non-profit's staff and residents, gathering feedback for the employee handbook on how to improve the clarity of the organizational policies.

Services Provided

Employee Handbook

After researching DC's labor laws and industry standards and analyzing the feedback received from the survey, the consultants compiled and formatted an employee handbook, which contains updated company policies and practices that would optimally serve the staff and residents of the non-profit. One of the changes was to enforce an inclusive, gender-neutral dress code policy.

Social Media Strategy

To ensure that the nonprofit is able to sustain social media growth, DCivitas organized Canva and graphic design workshops for the staff and residents of the Wanda Alston Foundation. Together, they prepared a best practices and brand identity document to supplement their strategic social media plan and also designed a series of Instagram posts as part of a social media campaign for Transgender Awareness Week.

PR Content Creation

To amplify Wanda Alston Foundation's name and impact, DCivitas also worked on developing content that captured the organization's brand and mission. The team of consultants wrote 2 stories to publish about the project...? They also produced videos that featured LGBTQ youth who have resided in Wanda Alston's housing facilities, giving them a platform to speak about their past experiences and how the foundation has supported them through their hardships.

“Wrote 2 stories to publish about the project/wanda alston foundation” is what Nadim had in notes below; i'm not really sure how to phrase it in a way that makes sense... were the stories published on their website?

Virtual Fundraiser Organization

In preparation for the virtual fundraiser, DCivitas reached out to numerous folks within and outside of the Wanda Alston Foundation to invite as guest speakers. The consultants successfully set up a collaboration with Riley Knoxx, a prominent transgender activist in DC, who served as a co-host for the virtual event.

Impact

In partnership with DCivitas, the Wanda Alston Foundation successfully organized a virtual fundraising event that garnered over 300 attendees and 3 noted corporate sponsors, raising \$70,000 to support the nonprofit's operations – it's most successful fundraiser to date. Furthermore, since collaborating with DCivitas, the Wanda Alston Foundation's Instagram engagement has increased by 200% and the organization has also received media recognition from renowned news outlets, having been featured in 2 articles by The Washington Post.

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What challenges was the client facing? Where did they need our help?

- They wanted help organizing a virtual fundraising event, writing up an employee handbook, asked for social media promotion/help, they had trouble organizing

events/switching to online/virtual since they always had in person events and no system in place for online ones

How did DCivitas strategize to solve the problem?

- Weekly meetings with June and Andrew (the heads of the organization), actively working with them to update them on progress
- Weekly team meetings with a team of 9 consultants
- depending on where they were on the project, consultants also got to work with the heads (not just project manager), met with a virtual planner to plan the virtual fundraiser, met with social media coordinator to discuss social media campaign
- Delegated tasks among consultants and established project deadlines; formulated solutions alongside consultants.

What solution did we provide to the client?

- Compiled and formatted an employee handbook, researching, writing, and updating organizational policies for clarity and to ensure that they optimally serve staff and residents of the non-profit while complying with DC labor laws and industry standards. (ex: (dress code policy changed to gender neutral from genedered)
- Created a survey to gather and analyze feedback from staff and residents regarding how to best improve the aforementioned policies.
- Prepared a best practices/brand identity document as part of a strategic social media plan;
- Organized Canva and graphic design workshops for staff and residents to ensure the nonprofit is able to sustain social media growth and to help residents develop professional skills.
- Wrote 2 stories to publish about the project/wanda alston foundation
- They recorded videos of the residents of the house to speak about their past experiences and how the foundation helped (the fundraiser was also to celebrate the opening of their second house)
- Virtual event was speakers from the organization and outside, the host was a prominent LGBTQ speaker in the DC community (they helped organize these collaborations)
- Worked to update their website, clarity, information, easier to navigate, etc

What was the impact of our solution?

Organized a virtual fundraising event with over 300 attendees and 3 noted corporate sponsors which raised \$70,000 to support the nonprofit's operations (largest in their history and to date). Increased Instagram engagement by 200% by designing and executing a sample social media campaign for Transgender Awareness Week.

They met up a week or two ago.

Still keep in touch, went to farmers fishers bakers, client gave gift/thank you bags to consultants, paid for their dinner, expressed extreme gratitude, she really stressed how much the fundraiser helped, its still their largest fundraiser even to date

Consults learned about more intersectional issues in DC, got to interact with DC, valued their experience and felt like it was a blessing and a privilege to work with them.